



“In India, two-thirds [of courses] will be tech-oriented, and one-third will be business oriented”

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“The world is moving towards skill-based hiring... You just need to have the skills for the job”

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training for roles such as CFO, CTO and CMO.

upGrad's Kumar says while there was a certain level of scepticism attached to online courses earlier, companies have become more accepting now. Kamlesh Vyas, Partner at Deloitte, says HR personnel working in the IT space respect these online courses. “The non-IT courses are considered extensions of hobbies and passions,” he says, adding that the IT industry is more accepting as it has always been at the forefront of any development or evolution. And therefore, students who have diplomas in technologies like cloud, AI, Internet of Things (IoT), and others have an edge, say experts. “IT as a sector has always valued executive education,” adds Damera. After the IT industry, it is in the consulting and the BSFI sectors where there are takers for these online courses.

“The world is moving towards what we call skill-based hiring, where they (companies) don't care whether you've done an MBA or engineering. You just need to have the skills for the job,” says Sekhar Garisa, CEO of jobs portal Foundit (previously Monster APAC & ME). A recruiter at an Indian data analytics major, who wishes to remain anonymous, says skills are important wherever hiring is concerned. “If a fresher does a data science course from an edtech company and has a strong grasp, we hire him. However, we have also seen cases where a person hasn't done any specialised course but has skills plus work experience,” says the recruiter, adding that the employee's performance and successful execution of client projects help determine their pay package when they switch jobs.

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While the young workforce is eager to upskill, how much do these courses cost? Courses start from ₹20,000 and go beyond ₹20 lakh for programmes that run from a week to three years. For instance, upGrad offers a range of courses that cost between ₹20,000 and ₹20 lakh. In the case of Hero Vired, which offers courses in data science, finance, technology, and more, the average pricing is ₹3.7-4 lakh, excluding GST. As for Scaler, which offers programmes in similar fields, the costs are in the range of ₹3.5-5 lakh. Technology courses like Generative AI, cloud and data science tend to be the most expensive due to the limited availability of offline learning opportunities for these subjects within traditional systems of education. “Their [traditional systems] cost structures are set. And therefore, they find it difficult to scale up,” says Munjal of Hero Vired.

Online courses are also generally cheaper than offline ones, especially for management courses at reputed institutes. Sample this: At IIMs, the fees for two-year MBA programmes start at ₹1 lakh and go up to ₹32 lakh. While there are government-run institutes like the Faculty of Management Studies (FMS) under the University of Delhi, where MBA courses cost between ₹50,000 and ₹1 lakh over two years, getting an admission into such colleges is difficult. “Only 1-2 per cent of students are able to make it to these colleges,” says Munjal of Hero Vired. upGrad Chairperson and Co-founder Ronnie Screwvala, in a recent podcast episode on the edtech industry, summed this up succinctly: “We are providing inclusivity, whereas the traditional colleges provide exclusivity.”

The big question, though, is: what is the ROI for those who enrol in such courses? Let us go back to Arumugam. On completing her full-stack software